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ACTIVISTS AND CHANGEMAKERS – WHY STUDENTS SHOULD BE THE HOPE TO COMBAT ENVIRONMENT & CLIMATE CHANGE



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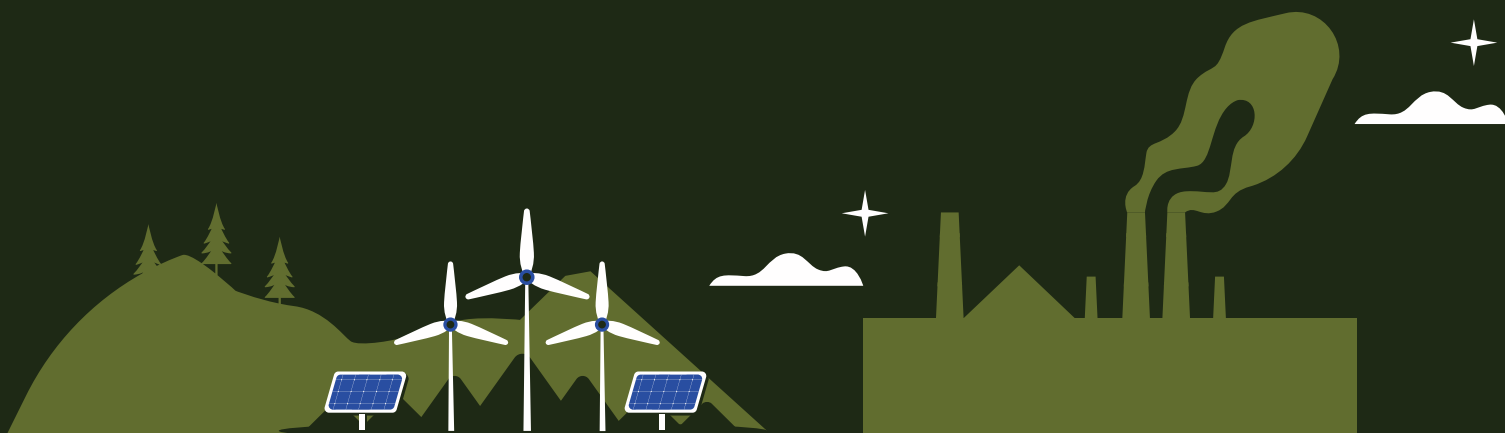
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Abstract

Over the past three decades, climate change has remained a global concern with its policy decisions and actions predominantly the responsibility of older people (United Nations (UN), 2021). Meanwhile, young people are the most susceptible to the effects of climate change since the effects of activities that cause climate change are subtle and occur in the future. In that regard, youth must play a key role in decision-making, while making efforts to both, directly and indirectly, influence the strategies and activities of decision-makers towards combatting climate change. The review revealed that young people, through transnational advocacy networks and youth-centred NGOs, are making strides in the fight against climate change. Empirical results of this study also revealed that young people actively advocate for climate change mitigation through their participation in climate campaigns and recycling of waste materials. Based on the findings, it is recommended that transnational organizations and youth NGOs are strengthened through adequate funding and seats at decision-making tables. This will increase their reach and influence. Further, governments and development partners should improve platforms that can ease the dissemination of climate change information and climate change education. This will increase awareness and knowledge of climate change in developing countries. Also, capacity development programmes should be geared towards developing the innovative capacities of young people to increase their abilities to develop technologies that protect the environment.





Introduction

Climate change which represents unprecedented but consistent changes in weather patterns remains a global problem with key interrelationships with economic growth, environmental degradation and poverty reduction (Narksompong & Limjirakan, 2015). This complex nature of climate change reflects the interconnectedness of the environment, economy and society. Thus, advancing policy action to curb environmental problems translates to sustainable development. Sustainable development, which focuses on development that meets the needs of the present generation without compromising the ability of the future generation to meet their own needs (WCED, 1987), necessitates meeting fundamental human needs in ways that preserve the life support systems of the planet (Kates et al., 2001). Despite the rising call for the sustainable exploitation of natural capital, the planet has overly become susceptible to several ills which have impeded its ability to support life and limited ecosystem services that humans and other living things derive from the environment. This vulnerability of the planet which limits its potential is generally caused by natural and artificial occurrences, leading to changes in environmental and climatic conditions of the earth. This has raised concerns about the need to protect the climate as reflected in the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC) which aims at protecting the climate system in the interest of present and future generations of humankind based on equity (UNFCCC, 1994). The social dimensions of sustainability raise equity concerns as regards climate change. These equity dimensions include the distribution of the impacts of climate change, the distribution of responsibilities, intergenerational dimensions, access to justice and public participation (Beg et al. 2000; Talan, 2020).

The impacts of climate change cannot be overemphasized. For instance, since the Industrial Revolution, the warming of the earth's surface is estimated between 1.10 and 1.50 Fahrenheit and precipitation has increased over the past century (Dell et al., 2012), although some regions have become wetter whereas others have become drier. Global warming or climate change has been further exacerbated by the continuous practices of humans such as; the continued increment in the emission of Greenhouse Gases (GHG), the over-exploitation of lands and poor forestry practices (International Panel on Climate Change (IPCC), 2014; Trenberth, 2018). In extension, carbon-based industrialization driven economic growth accounts for the anthropogenic climate change that continues to threaten the entire biosphere (Narksompong & Limjirakan, 2015).

The quest for rapid economic growth which is accompanied by rapid industrialization has over the past decades intensified the impacts of climate change on the environment and society (people). These impacts include the continual increment in sea levels and temperatures, altering wind patterns and melting glaciers and sea ice (Adediji et al., 2014). African countries have generally been the worst hit by climate change. According to Tol (2020), they are more susceptible to climate change given that these countries are hotter. More significantly, the agricultural sector, which is mainly rain-fed has been highly affected by climate change, thereby impeding Africa's economic growth and development which heavily depends on agricultural production (Asafu-Adjaye, 2014). Further, the efforts in understanding the implications of climate change continue to grow. Categorically, climate change has increased the risk of conflicts, poverty and hunger, undermined human rights and is a growing cause of forced migration, especially in developing countries (Sida, 2018).

There have been several debates concerning measures to curb the impact of climate change on both the environment and the livelihoods of people in Africa (Dube et al., 2016; Dube & Phiri, 2013). Whiles aspects of the debate focus on abating climate change (Glemarec, 2019; Malyan et al., 2019) other facets focus on measures that can ensure that individuals build resilient strategies to adapt to the increasing effects of climate change (Woodrow et al., 2018; Makate et al., 2019). While climate change negotiations are centred on the global level, climate change implementation and sustainable development responses will take place at the local, regional, and national levels.

This is because the impact of climate change on countries and communities necessitates localized responses and provides an opportunity to address and prioritize sustainable develo-



ment if the larger system of interdependent economic, social, and environmental forces is also taken into account (Narksompong & Limjirakan, 2015).



The localized responses to combat climate change and other environmental problems should involve the active participation of youth. The youth make up 17% of the world's population, or 1.2 billion people between the ages of 15 and 24, with the majority (87%) living in developing countries (UN Department of Economic and Social Affairs (UN DESA), 2019). Empowering today's youth to alleviate climate change impacts should be an educational priority since youth are the future citizens and decision-makers that must live with the impacts of climate change and take action on implementing solutions (MacKay, 2020). Thus, youth should be actively engaged in enacting policies geared towards combatting climate change.

Climate change education, especially for youth, is critical for enhancing people's ability to solve environmental and developmental concerns associated with climate change. Participation of youth in climate change response can assist in reorienting development paths toward sustainability. A restricted perspective on climate change that is unduly focused on the scientific and technical aspects of the problem can overlook the economic and social forces at work. Thus, a participatory approach to environment and climate change that involves the youth is therefore essential in many developing countries (Narksompong & Limjirakan, 2015). The youth are related to climate change in many ways. On one hand, their experiences with climate change can be pessimistic, where and on the other hand be positive (Han & Ahn, 2020). This necessitates youth participation in efforts to reduce the impact of climate change

Young people have played significant roles in various movements. In environmental management, young people have complemented governmental and non-governmental efforts to combat climate change. However, there is a growing level of inequity in participation in climate action so long as young people and students are concerned (Han & Ahn, 2020). Meanwhile, this group of people have higher levels of education, and a higher physical and mental state of well-being (O'Brien et al., 2018). These qualities can be effective in ensuring that the impact of climate change on the environment and human beings is minimal for future generations. Further, studies reveal that the direct exposure of youth to the impacts of climate change influences their concerns and activism about the environment (Strazdin & Skeat, 2011). However, young people's interpretation of climate change largely depends on their ontological positions in terms of whether knowledge is fixed and certain or context-specific and evolving (Fazey, 2010). Under circumstances where youth have succeeded in securing desired change, often on unrelated issues, youth may perceive problems related to climate change as opportunities for action and leadership (Hayward & Selboe, 2014; Schreiner et al. 2005).

Youth efforts to combat climate change and environmental problems have been both direct and indirect (Escobar, 2015; Hayward & Selboe, 2014). On one breadth, some youth are actively involved in improving environmental conditions by making efforts that directly affect the environment. Such efforts include tree planting exercises, waste segregation and recycling, community-based actions, awareness creation, sustainability campaign and other capacity-building programmes (United Nations, 2009; 2013). On another breadth, youth and students have been politically engaged in the fight against climate change and environmental problems (Manning, 2013; Fenton, 2010; Wayne et al., 2010). These levels of activism take the forms of issue-specific activism or low-threshold activism such as petition signing, social media campaigns and protests. Other radical efforts by youth include campaigns that challenge social and economic policies, including an emphasis on economic growth. Other efforts to transfer political and economic power away from fossil fuel industries and carbon polluters have included divestment campaigns, boycotts, and legal measures that highlight environmental justice (United Nations, 2013; Partridge, 2008, Fisher, 2016). These groups of youth fall under advocates of strong sustainability as opposed to weak sustainability. Some young people have made conservative efforts including consuming products that are eco-friendly or that were produced under eco-friendly conditions as well as using products that protect the environment from environmental problems and climate change.

Against this backdrop, this paper provides qualitative and quantitative evidence on knowledge of, perceptions and attitudes of young people towards climate change. The paper also elaborates on actions taken by young Africans to combat climate change.



Youth Awareness of Climate Change

Successful participation in climate action on all fronts largely depends on youth's awareness and extent of awareness of climate change and its impact. In fact, according to the UN (2015), awareness of climate change amounts to achieving Sustainable Development Goal 13 of taking urgent action to combat climate change. Youth can specifically battle climate change by working to fulfil SDG 13.3, which calls for promoting education, raising awareness, and strengthening human and institutional capacity for climate change mitigation, adaptation, impact reduction, and early warning (UN, 2015). Further, according to the Government of Kenya (GoK, 2013), public awareness of climate change induces a sense of responsibility for environmental and climate issues among people which fosters both direct and indirect actions toward combatting climate change (GoK, 2013). Studies conducted by Devkota and Phuyal (2017) and Ceaser et al. (2019) on youth's awareness of climate change in Kenya revealed that the majority of youth in Nepal (98%) and Kenya (68%) were aware of climate change. This is an indication of extensive education on climate change in developing countries as African and Asian youth are generally aware of environmental issues. According to Ceaser et al. (2019), African youths believe that climate change in Africa is mainly driven by deforestation and air pollution. However, a few youths with a deeper understanding of climate change highlight that it is mainly caused by some anthropogenic activities such as the burning of fossil fuels (Stern & Kaufmann, 2013).

Awareness creation on climate change and environmental issues has significantly increased over the past decades. Studies show that sources of information on climate change in many developing countries include television, the internet, newspaper and radio. This reiterates the need for the development of information and communication technology in developing countries. The findings of this study revealed that most young people received climate change information from schools. Further, other sources of climate change information, especially for literature include publications and journals, newspapers, and local libraries. In some countries, there are several environmental groups of different forms where education on climate change is provided.

The availability of information and communication technology as well as membership in environmental groups do not make an exhaustive list of the drivers of awareness of climate change among youth in developing countries. According to Devkota and Phuyal (2017), key drivers of youth's awareness of climate change include youth's level of education, their age, gender, access to formal education on climate change, access to training on climate change and environmental issues, participation in conversations relating to climate change on the family and society levels as well as access to mobile phone and use of the mobile phone for climate change learning.

While youth are aware of the concept of climate change; studies show that the depth of their awareness is relatively low. Students in developing countries do not have an in-depth understanding of climate change Devkota and Phuyal (2017) and this is reflected in the existence of knowledge gaps as regards climate change (Akrofi et al., 2019). According to Akrofi et al. (2019), African youth are largely unaware that meat consumption and waste generation are significant drivers of climate change. This indicates that the knowledge of youth in developing countries on climate change is limited to the obvious causes such as emission of greenhouse gases and desertification but not the indirect but significant causes. Further, empirical findings of Akrofi et al. (2019) show that youth are less knowledgeable about how climate change exacerbates conflicts, gender inequalities and job insecurity.





Youth Participation in Global Negotiations on climate change (Conventions and Protocols on Climate Change)

Kyoto Protocol

The Kyoto Protocol which was adopted in 1997 at the third conference of the parties of the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change commits highly industrialized countries and transition economies to limit and reduce greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions by agreed individual targets. The convention tasked these countries to enact policies and abatement measures to mitigate climate change and also make efforts to produce periodic reports (United Nations Climate Change (UNCC), 2021). The Kyoto Protocol was full-blown in 2005 under which 37 industrialized countries and the European Commission committed to reducing greenhouse emissions by 5 per cent. This protocol was mainly targeted at industries and thus saw little youth participation. In fact, during this time, there was little or no involvement of youth in climate activism or organized (Thew, 2018). That is, youth participation on the political front as regards climate change activism was inactive. However, the youth constituency expressed an immense urge to participate in climate change meetings, especially those of the United Nations.

Since the Kyoto Protocol, the youth constituency has been strengthened and has received attention from both state and non-state actors such as the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC). According to Thew (2018), young people have made considerable efforts to participate in conventions that are facilitated by UNFCCC. However, the youth's ability to engage with the UNFCCC is influenced by the availability of certain power sources, an indication that the potential for the agency is not equally available to all non-state actors in the UNFCCC (Nasiritousi et al., 2016). According to Nasiritousi et al. (2016), given various sources of power, youth will choose a source based on the level of recognition and agency that gives them the highest number of opportunities to participate in negotiations, although according to state actors, power sources and strategies are not always associated with the desired response or outcome.

Thew (2018) found that a high self-perception of agency increases young participants' propensity to offer constructive amendments which can enhance recognition and agency. On the other hand, a low self-perception of an agency causes youth to perceive recognition to be absent. This causes young people to channel their efforts towards asserting their relevance and/or challenging procedural legitimacy. Although young people take various measures to advance their cause towards increasing recognition, decision-makers have, over the past decades, not given young people the necessary attention as regards climate action. This could be attributed to the fact that the government's attention has been on climate financing when young people are not able to provide these resources.

Challenges faced by young people in climate activism are not limited to inadequate attention received from decision-makers. A widely recognized challenge associated with climate change activism among young people hinges on the financial constraint (Feyen et al., 2020). Financial constraint serves as a major hindrance to youth regarding their utilization of appropriate modes of participation (such as side-events at summits and conferences) in climate activism (Feyen et al., 2020). Also, young climate change activists require financial resources to develop professional relationships with key actors over time. These professional relationships are fostered through active participation in conferences and summits. Thus, financial constraint to participation implies an underdeveloped agency compared with better-resourced non-state actors.



The constituency of Youth Non-Governmental Organizations to UNFCCC

The rise in the number of youth activists against climate change (such as SustainUS, Earth Uprising, Youth 4 Nature, Earth Guardians and Zero Hour) has led to the formation of several youth organizations. These youth organizations, although were either non-existent at the time of the Kyoto Protocol or could not participate in the convention, have successfully secured a seat at subsequent conventions and summits on environmental protection and climate change activism. These conventions and summits have served as platforms for the youth to proffer appropriate actions toward fighting against environmental challenges and climate change.

Young people have persistently expressed interest in the UNFCCC by participating in external conferences and presenting several declarations to the Conferences of Parties (COPs) before formally registering with the UNFCCC (Thew, 2019). Also, young people formed various delegations to participate directly in the COPs, united to advocate on behalf of youth and eventually gained constituency status (UNFCCC, 2010). Generally, membership in the UNFCCC as regards youth is loosely restricted to young people under the age of 30. However, fees are not accrued to membership nor are members required to make any form of commitment. Young people formed non-governmental organizations (NGOs) taking up different forms of activism roles. These NGOs became popularly known as Youth NGOs or YOUNGOs which also function as a Transnational Advocacy Network operating within UNFCCC. This youth constituency coordinates various transnational organizations that work on the lines of climate activism and unites both moderate and more radical 'insiders' and 'outsiders' (Rodrigues, 2009). Currently, most of the young are located in developed European countries such as the United Kingdom, the Netherlands and Belgium. The most prominent YOUNGO in a developing country notable for voluntary activities in the spheres of climate action is the Indian Youth Climate Network. The literature indicates that Africa is largely underrepresented in youth activism on global fronts. This reinforces the need for policy frameworks and institutional and financial support that can capacitate African youth to fully participate in global conventions concerning climate change.

It is noteworthy that the YOUNGO makes efforts to ensure that it has representation both in the Global North and in the Global South through its election. These delegates are mainly responsible for liaison with the UNFCCC Secretariat. However, the delegates mainly operate voluntarily where they are unpaid. Also, youth delegates do not take up leadership roles. This implies that although young people are allowed to participate in a high-level panel of experts concerning climate change, they are not given opportunities to participate in decision-making. young are bound by the rules of observer participation. This means that their participation in the UNFCCC is limited to only attending meetings. However, these young delegates are not allowed to participate in negotiations. However, young people have developed participatory strategies and a level of agency. It is noteworthy that there are actors who have the ability and opportunities to participate in intergovernmental meetings and there are agents who, through their activities, influence the outcome of these events. Over the past decade, youth have formed part of these agents. Thus, the agency of youth in climate action cannot be underestimated.

Meanwhile, several studies (Lee et al., 2020; Thomson, 2021) have acknowledged young people's strong mental faculties and innovativeness in the area of climate change. In fact, to date, young people have actively developed appropriate technologies that can be functional in abating the detrimental effects of climate change.

The overarching challenge to youth participation in conventions on climate change remains their limited access to financial resources and funding. As mentioned earlier, given that YOUNGOs mainly operate as volunteers, investing their own time and money, turnover is high as continuous attendance to the conventions is costly. These limited funding opportunities available to young impede their sustained engagement with the UNFCCC. Young people are only able to maintain a long-term engagement when they secure employment and/or sponsorship. Further, the representation of YOUNGOs is skewed to the Global North youths. This is because funding opportunities are particularly unavailable for youths in the Global South.





Also, young people in this region encounter several difficulties in obtaining visas and this impedes their ability to be more representative. As a result, the UNFCCC's representatives for international youth are typically from privileged backgrounds.

Transnational Advocacy Networks

Non-state actors including youth NGOs possess different levels of resource, capacity and skill, and have a stronger networked organization that tend to dominate (Bostrom & Hallstrom, 2010). However, to increase their agency, non-state actors unite in transnational advocacy networks (a network of NGOs across different countries) which span international borders. These transnational advocacy networks share expertise and resources while campaigning for shared values. They are shaped and shaped by varied members. Non-state actors lack the mandate to create intergovernmental policy and frame their knowledge to appeal to state actors. Generally, their advocacy takes four distinct forms which include:

- (a) Information politics, or the ability to quickly and convincingly convey politically useful information to where it will have the greatest influence.
- (b) Symbolic politics, or the ability to use symbols, acts, or stories to explain a situation or claim to an audience that is often thousands of miles away.
- (c) Leverage politics, or the ability to enlist the help of powerful actors to influence a situation in which weaker members of a network are unlikely to have a say; and
- (d) Accountability politics, or the attempt to compel more powerful actors to follow vaguer policies or principles that they formally endorsed.



Youth engagement in the fight against climate change and other environmental problems has been actively conducted through transnational advocacy networks formed by these young people. These transnational advocacy networks actively shape the choices of NGOs as regards the methods to employ in the fight against climate change (Hadden & Jasney, 2017). In essence, the NGOs' decisions to protest or conduct media engagements in the fight against climate change are largely influenced by transnational organizations. For instance, a study conducted on women's empowerment and climate change adaptation by Christoff and Sommer (2018) found that transnational advocacy networks are functional in increasing the scale and scope of climate change projects. Hence, transnational advocacy networks play key roles in increasing the ability of climate change projects to effectively reach more people. Considering the potential of young people who are in their physical and mental primes, transnational advocacy networks that are densely concentrated with young people can have radically transformational qualities. This can further foster effective advocacy as well as guide the advocacy strategies of youth NGOs that are inclined towards the environment and climate action. The formation of transnational advocacy networks, therefore, serves as a perfect platform for young people to directly contribute to change as regards climate change and other environmental problems in a political climate that is characterized by powerful interests, strong rhetoric and weak action on climate change (O'Brien et al., 2018).





Methodology

Research Design

The study conducted primary research to ascertain information on practical micro-actions and behaviours of individual youth towards climate change and environmental problems. To execute this primary research, the study adopted the survey design. This research design allows for the description of what young people across the African continent are doing to combat climate change, in what amount and in what context (Isaac & Michael, 1997). The design also allows for the establishment of baselines against which future comparisons can be made. The study was conducted with unknown population size. Digitalized questionnaires were distributed across known social media platforms including Facebook and WhatsApp to elucidate information from young people who are passionate about the fight against climate change. The study employed a quantitative approach to analyze data collected from young people across different African countries and regions including Central Africa, West Africa, and Eastern Africa. The sampling procedure was random and responses were from 32 young Africans.

Data

The study used both primary and secondary data. Secondary data were obtained through a review of related and relevant literature on the topic whilst primary data was collected by the use of digitized questionnaires. The data collected from the respondents were on their socio-demographic characteristics, knowledge of and perceptions of climate change and other environmental problems, efforts to mitigate climate change and environmental problems on the individual levels and access to institutional support services that can enhance their fight against climate change and environmental problems.

The data collected was analyzed using descriptive statistics including means and frequencies of continuous and categorical data respectively. The data analysis is presented in charts and tables.

Results and Discussions

Role of Change Agents

Figure 1 presents suggestions by the respondents on agents who are responsible to promote climate change activism. The results show that the majority of the young people in Africa suggest that individuals should be at the forefront of the fight against climate change and environmental problems. Also, some of the young respondents believe that international organizations and national governments are in better positions to fight climate change and environmental problems. Individuals are generally responsible for combatting climate change by taking up actions including reduction of consuming products that were produced through a process that requires the emission of greenhouses (Javadinejad et al., 2019). According to Javadinejad et al. (2019) governments of developing countries are responsible for effective urban planning, societal controls through the imposition of carbon quotas, and the enforcement of the use of cleaner technologies.



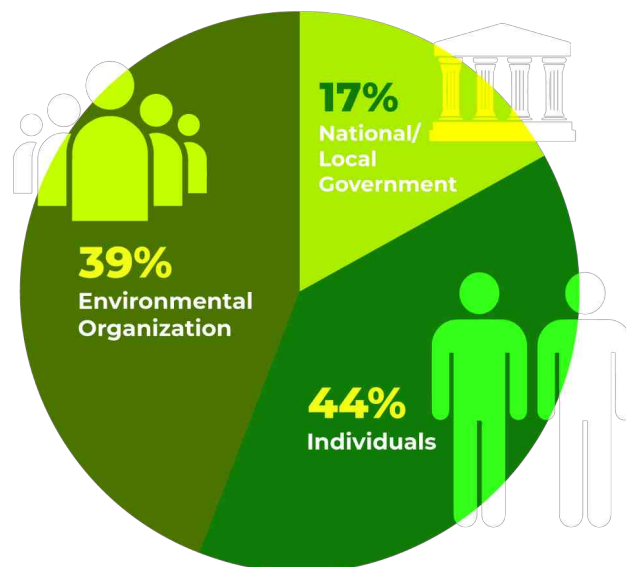


Figure 1: Suggested agents of change regarding climate change

Personal activities that could save the climate

Table 1 presents information on the personal activities that young people do which could both, directly and indirectly, protect the environment and combat climate change. Through a thorough review of related literature on climate change, the study elucidated information on key activities including walking or cycling, usage of public transport rather than private transport, turning off electricity bulbs when not in use, buying energy-efficient bulbs, patronizing organic foods, recycling, and taking part in climate campaigns. The results of this survey revealed that young people largely undertake these activities to save money, although this intuition was not found among the majority of the respondents. Also, some young people participated in these activities for convenience purposes. Categorically, it was found that a significant proportion of the respondents (44%) used public transport because it was convenient whereas the same proportion of respondents made this decision to save money.

Table 1: Personal activities that could protect the environment source: Survey data (2021)

From the survey, it was found that major activities that young people undertook to protect the environment and combat climate change include but are not limited to recycling glass and other items as well as participating in climate change campaigns. Coupled with the aforementioned activities, several state and non-state actors have taken urgent sustainable actions towards climate change in various countries in both the global North and South. According to the United Nations Joint Framework Initiative on Children, Youth and Climate Change, young people have been actively involved in key projects that are contributing immensely to combatting climate change. Key among such projects in the Global South include the Bamboo Bicycle project, Production of Biodiesel from used vegetable oil, Energy Saving to Reduce Carbon Emissions, Cyclone Proof School, and the El Mouddaa Adaptation Initiative project which fosters sustainable land and water management.





Conclusions

Climate change has received enormous attention over the past decades due to its impact on the productivity of various sectors of the global economy. Developing countries face the most adverse impacts of climate change given that the majority of the livelihoods of their citizens depend on a favourable climate. To this end, it is necessary to foster the active participation of all persons in the fight against climate change. The role of young persons in the fight against climate change cannot be overemphasized. This paper revealed that young people will be worse off in the future as regards the impacts of climate change. Although it is the responsibility of governments and development partners to undertake measures that mitigate climate, the onus lies on youth to ensure that they are not involuntarily affected by the current environmental-unfriendly activities that can be detrimental to their health and productivity in the future. This fact places the youth in a better position to advocate against climate change since they are characterized by the drive and passion to undertake emancipatory causes of actions to hold their governments accountable.

Holding governments accountable requires youth to engage in several forms of actions. The paper revealed that some young people from transnational organizations and other youth-based non-governmental organizations influence state actors and other development partners that have various capacities to enact policies and affect change. Further, it was revealed that young people engaged in activities on the individual and micro levels that have positive impacts on the environment and reduced climate change. Specifically, young people have been actively engaged in climate change campaigns and waste recycling activities which are largely ecofriendly.

Recommendations

Based on the review, it is recommended that:

1. Government and development partners strengthen transnational advocacy networks and youth NGOs to ensure an increased influence on decision-makers. This can be done by capacitating these organizations with the funds needed for research and advocacy activities.
2. There should be more platforms that can ease the dissemination of climate change information and climate change education. This will increase awareness and knowledge of climate change in developing countries.
3. Capacity development programmes should be geared towards developing the innovative capacities of young people to increase their abilities to develop technologies that protect the environment.





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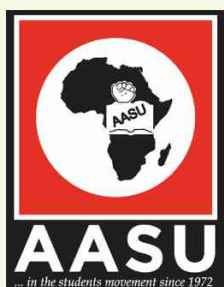
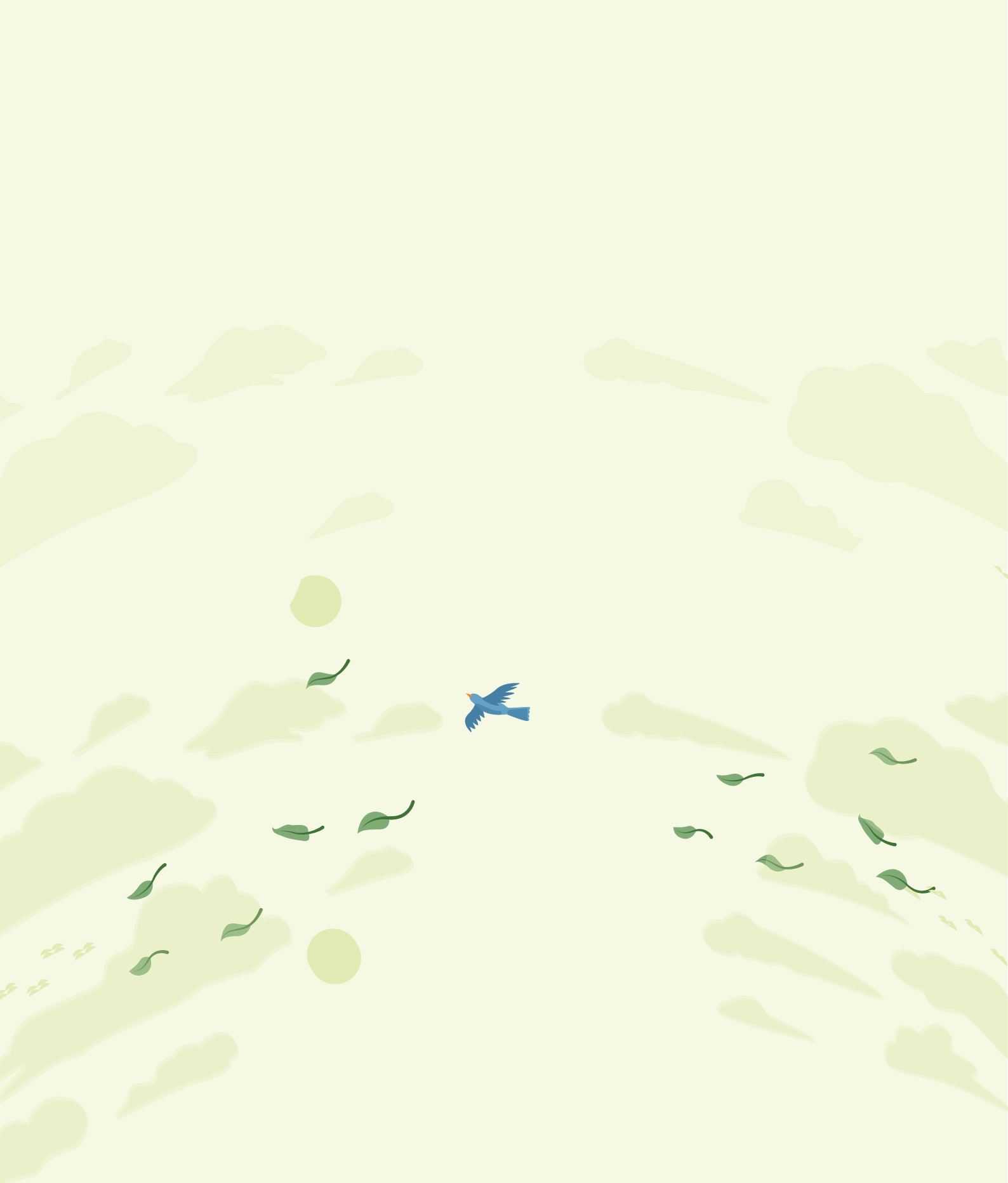
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